

THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Pull-Aside Meeting with President Alija Izetbegovic of the Republic of Bosnia-Herzegovina (U)

PARTICIPANTS: U.S.
The President
Warren Christopher, Secretary of State
Anthony Lake, Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs
Richard Holbrooke, Assistant Secretary of State for European and Canadian Affairs
Alexander Vershbow, Senior Director for European Affairs, NSC Staff (Notetaker)

Bosnia-Herzegovina
Alija Izetbegovic, President
Kresimir Zubak, President of the Federation
Muhamed Sacirbey, Minister of Foreign Affairs
Hasan Muratovic, Minister for Relations with the UN
Other Advisors

DATE, TIME December 14, 1995, 9:55-10:05 a.m.
AND PLACE: U.S. Ambassador's Residence, Paris, France

The President: You are absolutely right about the importance of the elections. They are an important measure of success for us as well. We can't leave honorably if the elections aren't done right. We will do all we can. I will emphasize the importance of the elections with the Europeans today. I will also announce some reconstruction funds. ~~(C)~~

One of the greatest concerns we faced in seeking Congressional support, and an issue that we have raised with you before, is the safety of our troops in the event the Mujahedin do not leave and if you do not end your military and operational intelligence cooperation with Iran. Our people are vulnerable. If any action were taken by these forces against our troops, it could shatter the whole operation. It could jeopardize our ability to equip and train your forces. As you know, I told the Congress that we will equip and train your forces -- this is something we must do

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or else there will not be a lasting peace. I am strongly committed to this. But if we were to lose a couple of soldiers to forces connected to Iran, it could wreck the whole thing. So I want to do what I promised to do, but this is the one area that could undermine my commitment. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: As I told you earlier, your troops will be completely safe. The units of the Mujahedin have been dismantled. In the days to come, we will give you more details. The majority of these forces have already left. But there are small numbers that do not have any place to go. They are political opponents in their home countries, and many have families in Bosnia-Herzegovina. But as military units, they have ceased to exist. I understand your concern on this. There will be individuals who stay, but it will be as civilians and in parts of the country in which they will be under complete control. We don't know what to do with them as persons, but they are not soldiers anymore, and they have given a solemn promise that they will not deal with anything military. We will watch them. It is in our interest not to create any problems in this regard. If you provide us with evidence that people are terrorists, we will take action. But the Mujahedin units do not exist. ~~(C)~~

The President: I understand why they came. You needed help wherever you could find it. Those were desperate times. But we are your friends. We want to help -- to make the Federation work, to make Bosnia a unified state in every respect. But this problem could destroy the public base of support in the U.S. for IFOR. We will work with you and tell you what we know, but this is still a potentially serious problem. We are doing what we can to guard against this danger. We will take you at your word.

~~(C)~~

Secretary Christopher: Let me say a few words about the importance of making a success of the Federation. We heard considerable worry from the Congress about the Federation's future. Providing a real role for the Croats is going to be very important. In this regard, we are pleased that President Zubak is here. I know you will do your part. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: We are doing everything in our power to ensure that the Federation functions. Three days ago, we had a meeting of the Federation parliament. Things are moving forward. Between December 20 and 22, some very sensitive laws should be passed -- on defense and formation of a joint army and joint police force. Judging by what I have seen, therefore, things are improving. ~~(C)~~

Secretary Christopher: You also signed a good agreement in Dayton which needs to be filled out. ~~(C)~~

The President: What about the Serbs in the suburbs of Sarajevo? Can you do more to discourage them from leaving and to make them feel that they will be treated fairly? ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: Yesterday I had a meeting on this subject with Milosevic that lasted nearly two hours. I told him -- and I will repeat this in my speech -- that the Serbs in Sarajevo will be given a choice as to whether to leave or stay. We are calling on them to stay. We are trying to establish contact; we have sent delegations to speak with them, but they don't dare to see us. I even asked the German Ambassador to go to those suburbs where Farben had a factory to encourage them to remain. ~~(C)~~

Richard Holbrooke: The Serbs will talk with you after Admiral Smith and his forces arrive. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: That is possible. Once the forces of Karadzic leave, there will be a period when no army is in those areas. Then we will have a better opportunity to contact the Serbs. We are interested in seeing them stay. We want to maintain a cosmopolitan picture in Sarajevo. ~~(C)~~

-- End of Conversation --

Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

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